

such procedures) are treated as 'day-care' procedures and are covered. Check the details of the day-care clause, what will be covered, how much will be paid and how long you have to stay to claim.

Eight, **look at the 'no-claims bonus' feature**. When you don't make a claim in a year, you get rewarded by the insurance company. It does this by giving a 'no-claims bonus' (NCB). The usual way is to raise your cover by 10 per cent for the same premium. If your cover was Rs 15 lakhs, for a premium of Rs 25,000, when you have a claim-free year, you get a cover of Rs 16.5 lakhs for the same premium.

Claims

Your search for that good policy is not over till you understand the claims history of the company you finally choose. You know if a telecom service is good or not when you use it. It is very here and now, but for a medical policy, the moment of truth is when you file a claim. Does the insurer pay up? How much does he pay? Is the process easy? How quickly does the company respond to complaints?

These are questions that you must think about at the time of buying your policy. Unfortunately, in India, claims data is not standardized and is difficult to get. The regulator has not thought the disclosure of data through so as to make it meaningful to consumers. Ask the agents these questions on claims before you buy.

One, **how many claims does the company settle?** Out of 100, if the company's claims history does not settle more than ninety-five claims, don't buy from the firm. Claims are a tricky area because the companies club together group and individual claims data. Group claims get paid far more than individual claims. Ideally the disclosure on claims should be product-wise and not clubbed as one big number.

Two, **look at the claim-complaints data and look for a policy that has less than thirty complaints on every 10,000 claims made**. Be careful of firms that give data on complaints as a percentage of policies sold. What is relevant is how many